



Doing Applied Research

MIXTAPE TRACK



1. Style, grammar, length, and structure
2. Engaging with AI during the writing process
3. Writing an effective introduction
4. Tips for tables

Media attention and Vaccine Hesitancy: Examining the mediating effects of Fear of COVID-19 and the moderating role of Trust in leadership

Lulin Zhou, Sabina Ampon-Wireko, Xinglong Xu, Prince Edwudzie Quansah, and Ebenezer Larnyo

Published: February 18, 2022 <https://doi.org/10.1371/journal.pone.0263610>

53 Save	1 Citation
2,728 View	1 Share

- What type of journal are you targeting?
 - Economics journals and, for instance, PLOS ONE have distinctive styles
- Let's imagine that you're targeting an economics journal
 - Within economics, journals have distinctive styles
 - Tailor your manuscript to a general interest journal (e.g., *American Economic Review*) or a field journal (e.g., *Journal of Public Economics*)
 - Read a few articles in the journal that you're targeting

Style and Tone

- Engaging without being chatty or informal
 - More formal than the language you hear being used in seminars
 - Avoid “get” and “got”
 - Avoid using contractions (e.g., won’t, don’t, can’t, shouldn’t)
 - Avoid this construction:

“...we use for our main calibration the value 0.38, i.e. the median of the elasticity estimates in the literature.”

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“...we use for our main calibration the value 0.38, i.e. the median of the elasticity estimates in the literature.”

Please notice
the comma!

“...we use for our main calibration the value 0.38 (i.e., the median of the elasticity estimates in the literature).”

I much prefer this
construction

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i.e. the median of the elasticity estimates in the
literature.”

- Read what you wrote out loud
 - Does each sentence set up the next?
 - Does each paragraph set up the next?
- Don’t reinvent the wheel
 - Read some classics. How did Charles and Guryan (2008) begin their introduction? What are they doing with the opening sentence of the first paragraph?

Prejudice and Wages: An Empirical Assessment of Becker's *The Economics of Discrimination*

Kerwin Kofi Charles and Jonathan Guryan

University of Chicago and National Bureau of Economic Research



I. Introduction

Becker's (1957) seminal *The Economics of Discrimination* launched the formal analysis of labor market discrimination among economists. Becker's analysis focused on the relationship between racial prejudice among whites and discrimination against racial minorities in a competitive model. In contrast to much of the contemporaneous literature, Becker formalized the definition of racial preferences...

I'd call this the “classic” way to structure an economics paper

1. Introduction

2. Background

2.1. The theory

2.2. Literature review

3. Data

4. Empirical Strategy

5. Results

5.1. Robustness checks

5.2. Extensions

6. Conclusion

1. Introduction

2. Background

- 2.1. Desegregation of hospitals
- 2.2. Racial prejudice and infant health
- 2.3. Trends in the Black-white infant mortality gap

3. Hospital Desegregation and Infant Mortality

“Did the hospital desegregation campaign contribute to the steep decline in Black post-neonatal mortality in the Deep South during the 1960s and early 1970s?”

“Using OLS, we estimate the following equation...”

“The results provide evidence for...”

- 3.1. Estimates based on Callaway Sant’Anna (2021)
- 3.2. Reconciling our results with those of Almond et al. (2026)

4. Other Effects of Hospital Desegregation

- 4.1. Maternal mortality
- 4.2. Fertility

5. Conclusion

Length

- For a field journal, aim for 18-23 pages of text, 5-6 figures and tables (combined)
 - Thirty pages of text and 10 figures/tables is, in general, too much! Referees and editors have short attention spans.
 - Manuscripts aimed at a general interest journal will be longer (sometimes, much longer)
- More figures than tables
 - Try to write a paper without tables?
- Extra tables and figures can go in an appendix
- The revision process is usually going to add text, tables, and figures

Grammar

- Make sure there is a one-to-one correspondence between in-text citations and references
- Use a consistent style for the references
 - Include the first names of the authors. The editor is looking at your references for potential referees.
- Pay someone to read your paper over for typos and grammatical errors

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Should you use generative AI to proofread for typos, spelling and grammar mistakes?

Of course you should!



Should you use generative AI to help you write?



Should you use generative AI to help you write?

OPINION
BRET STEPHENS

I'm Begging You: Never Write With A.I.



By **Bret Stephens**
Opinion Columnist

Aug. 4, 2026

This column isn't so much an argument as it is a plea: Don't use artificial intelligence to help you write. Never let A.I. do your writing for you.

Quick Poll

1. Do you use generative AI for “basic checks of grammar, spelling, and punctuation”?

Quick Poll

1. Do you use generative AI for “basic checks of grammar, spelling, and punctuation”?
2. Do you use generative AI as a copyeditor?



Search Wikipedia	Search
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[The Chicago Manual of Style](#) states that **copy editing** encompasses "simple mechanical corrections through substantial remedial work on literary style, clarity, disorganized passages, baggy prose, muddled tables and figures, and the like...".

Quick Poll

1. Do you use generative AI for “basic checks of grammar, spelling, and punctuation”?
2. Do you use generative AI as a copyeditor?
3. Do you use generative AI to “take the first pass” at writing sentences/paragraphs?



ChatGPT ▾

What's on the agenda today?

Write a well-structured paragraph in the style of an academic economist that integrates the following points: (1) We know very little about how marijuana affects brain function. (2) The use of marijuana by teenagers has been increasing over the past two decades....



AI Policy, American Journal of Health Economics

AJHE views generative AI as a tool that, when used responsibly, can improve productivity and streamline the research process...

Authors must disclose use of large language models (LLMs) in the research process when LLMs are used to:

1. Write the initial draft of a paper or substantially rewrite your manuscript in a way that either substantively alters meaning or would merit coauthorship had the changes been made by a human.
2. Generate substantial intellectual content, such as creating data for analysis or generating hypotheses.



Generative AI policies for journals

Disclosure

Authors should disclose the use of AI Tools for manuscript preparation in a separate AI declaration statement in their manuscript upon submission and a statement will appear in the published work. Authors should document their use of AI, including the name of the AI Tool used, the purpose of the use, and the extent of their oversight. Declaring the use of AI Tools supports transparency and trust between authors, readers, reviewers, editors and contributors and facilitates compliance with the terms of use of the relevant AI Tool. Basic checks of grammar, spelling and punctuation need no declaration. AI use in the research process should be declared and described in detail in the methods section.

Authorship

Authors should not list AI Tools as an author or co-author, nor cite AI Tools as an author. Authorship implies responsibilities and tasks that can only be attributed to and performed by humans. Each (co-) author is



Basic checks of grammar, spelling and punctuation need no declaration. AI use in the research process should be declared and described in detail in the methods section.

If you use AI when writing, should you declare and describe what you did?

What are the consequences for failing to declare?



ELSEVIER

Leading Journals in Economics



Journal of
Public Economics



Labour
Economics



Journal of
Health Economics



European
Economic Review

Declaration of generative AI and AI-assisted technologies in the writing process

While preparing this work, the author(s) used Grammarly and ChatGPT to correct the grammar and writing style. After using this tool/service, the author(s) reviewed and edited the content as needed and take(s) full responsibility for the publication's content.

Scope Match

 [About Scope Match](#)

Scope check match:

 Highly in scope

Key themes in the manuscript:

legalization; cannabis; psychiatry; purchasing;
environmental health; medicine; legal status

Screening Comments

- 1 This manuscript was flagged by our screening tool as having a high likelihood it contains machine-generated content. We advise considering the manuscript in light of the journal and Wiley's AI Policy, but please be advised that this result alone is not sufficient to prove the use of AI and it should not be used as a primary decision-making tool.

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Screening Comments

-  If a statement on AI has not already been provided in the manuscript, we recommend asking the authors to include a statement on whether AI was used in the preparation of their manuscript, the parts of the manuscript affected, and the steps taken to verify the output of the AI tool.

Me: What don't I like about this sentence?

We view our research as making a general contribution to the surprisingly sparse quasi-experimental literature on how medical innovation affects racial health disparities...In addition, our research makes a more specific contribution to the largely descriptive literature on SRT and the health of newborns. Medical studies have shown that the introduction of SRT in the United States coincided with a reduction in neonatal mortality among VLBW infants...

ChatGPT:

1. **“In addition” sounds like filler.**

It's generic connective tissue. Your paragraph already has a clear hierarchy (general → specific), so this reads like spoken scaffolding rather than intentional structure.

2. **“makes a more specific contribution” is vague and slightly bureaucratic.**

It names the move without showing it. You're telling the reader that the contribution is “more specific” instead of just *being* specific.

3. **“largely descriptive literature” is doing quiet evaluative work—but weakly.**

It hedges. You're signaling a gap (descriptive vs. causal), but in a softened way that blunts the contrast you actually rely on in the next sentence.

Me: Please suggest alternative wording

ChatGPT:

Here are alternatives that keep your intent but drop the filler and tighten the move from general → specific:

1. Minimal, no meta language

We also study the effects of SRT on newborn health.

2. Slightly more formal, still lean

We also examine how the introduction of SRT affected newborn health.

3. Keep a hint of contribution framing, but cleaner

We also contribute to the literature on SRT and newborn health.

4. Signal narrowing explicitly (without “In addition”)

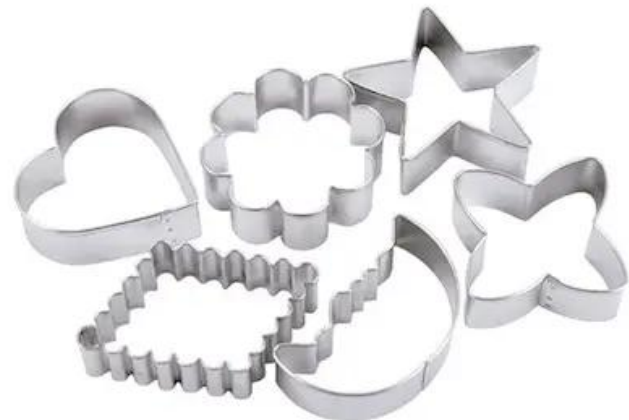
More specifically, we examine how the introduction of SRT affected newborn health.

5. Emphasize the gap you’re about to exploit

We examine how the introduction of SRT affected newborn health, a setting studied primarily descriptively.

Writing an effective introduction

- The introduction is, by far, the most important part of your paper
 - Many (most?) editors will not read past your introduction
 - Many (most?) referees have made up their minds by the end of the introduction
- Introductions are becoming longer and longer
 - Especially true at the best journals (e.g., the AEJs)
 - Credibility revolution → more emphasis on context/institutional details
 - Much of your introduction is going to be “defensive”
 - Describe the obvious threats to ID
 - How are these threats addressed?
- Cookie-cutter introductions



REPUBLICAN SUPPORT AND ECONOMIC HARDSHIP: THE ENDURING EFFECTS OF THE OPIOID EPIDEMIC

Carolina Arteaga
Victoria Barone

Working Paper 33904
<http://www.nber.org/papers/w33904>

I. **Introduction.** The opioid epidemic stands as one of the most tragic public health crises to affect the United States in the past century (Cutler and Glaeser, 2021)...The unfolding of the epidemic has coincided with a historical moment of enhanced partisanship and polarization in the United States...

1. The opening paragraph motivates your study. It provides general background information and—hopefully—convinces the reader that the research topic is important.

Previous studies have explored the effects of economic conditions, globalization, trade, automation, and immigration on political ideology and polarization... Less attention has been paid to the effects of health crises on political preferences...

2. Second paragraph briefly describes the results of previous studies, highlighting the gap in the literature that you are filling.

In this paper, we document how the opioid epidemic transformed the political landscape in communities that faced the most severe impacts of the crisis in terms of mortality and economic hardship.

3. Your research question comes at the start of the 2nd or 3rd paragraph. If you wait until the 4th or 5th paragraph, you risk desk rejection!

To do so, we uncover rich geographic, quasi-exogenous variation in exposure to the epidemic originating from detailed features of the initial marketing strategy for prescription opioids. We obtain this information from unsealed court records drawn from litigation against Purdue Pharma—manufacturer of OxyContin, the prescription opioid at the center of the crisis. These records show that at the dawn of the opioid epidemic in 1996, pharmaceutical marketing efforts were concentrated on the cancer pain market, with a plan to quickly expand within the same geographic areas to the much larger noncancer pain market...

4. Introduce your ID strategy soon (immediately?) after your research question. Do not be afraid of providing context and institutional details.

Why provide these institutional details? There is no statistical test of exogeneity. These details are what makes or breaks your ID strategy.

We start by showing the link between Purdue Pharma's initial marketing for OxyContin and future growth in prescription opioid use. Specifically, we estimate a strong positive relationship between cancer mortality in 1996 and prescription opioid use following the launch of OxyContin...

5. Next, describe your main results. You are NOT writing a mystery novel. The reader should know what to expect by the end of the introduction.

We provide several tests that support our empirical design and the robustness of our results...We rule out multiple alternative explanations that could drive our results. We control for geographic exposure to economic, political, media, environmental and health shocks and for...

6. What are the obvious threats to ID? Provide an overview of how you address these threats.

We contribute to the literature on the opioid epidemic in two ways. First, we introduce a new source of within-state variation in exposure to the crisis by leveraging the role of early marketing efforts...

Second, we conduct the first comprehensive community-level examination of how the opioid epidemic has shaped the economic, health, and political outlooks of the hardest-hit communities...

7. List your contributions. Remember, a good paper probably only makes one or two genuine contributions.

It is a big mistake to list too many contributions. It is a big mistake to claim to be advancing several different fields.

The remainder of the paper is organized as follows. In Section 2, we provide historical context, discuss previous studies, and describe some of the challenges faced by Blacks today when trying to gain access to high-quality hospital care. In addition, we show that the Black-White postneonatal mortality gap declined faster in the Deep South than in other regions of the country, and we discuss potential drivers of this phenomenon. **In Section 3, we report estimates of the effect of the hospital desegregation campaign on Black postneonatal mortality in the Deep South, and document why our estimates are so different from those of Almond et al. (2006), who found that the campaign reduced Black postneonatal mortality in Mississippi.** In Section 4, we estimate the effect of the campaign on the choice of where to give birth. Section 5 concludes.

8. Roadmap paragraph at the end of the introduction?

Practical tips for your tables

Table 1: Estimation results using all cases and variables

	Intercept (μ)		Treatment effect (α)	
	Estimate	Confidence Interval	Estimate	Confidence Interval
own_with_equity	50.88%	(48.63%, 53.13%)	1.12%	(0.33%, 1.92%)
own_no_equity	0.49%	(0.35%, 0.62%)	0.01%	(-0.07%, 0.08%)
rent	43.35%	(41.14%, 45.56%)	-0.87%	(-1.66%, -0.09%)
has_mortgage	60.73%	(58.24%, 63.23%)	1.07%	(0.22%, 1.92%)
home_equity	\$102,585.26	(\$93,756.00, \$111,414.53)	\$2,226.40	(\$324.21, \$4,128.60)
behind	2.49%	(1.91%, 3.07%)	-0.02%	(-0.19%, 0.14%)
months_behind	3.20	(2.24, 4.15)	-0.00	(-0.34, 0.33)
likely_behind	8.67%	(6.94%, 10.40%)	-0.03%	(-0.38%, 0.32%)
foreclose	11.95%	(5.14%, 18.76%)	0.03%	(-2.41%, 2.47%)
housing_asst	3.98%	(3.24%, 4.71%)	0.08%	(-0.12%, 0.28%)
in_public	13.26%	(11.78%, 14.74%)	0.15%	(-0.35%, 0.65%)
gvt_rent	4.93%	(3.77%, 6.09%)	0.14%	(-0.19%, 0.47%)
int_rate	4.59%	(4.43%, 4.74%)	-0.01%	(-0.04%, 0.01%)

Point estimates and 95% confidence intervals of the parameters from (1) as found using imputations generated via the primary OHIE/PSID data fusion model that includes all cases and variables.

This table is from a recent submission to a top field journal. What can be improved?

The title could be much more informative. Must read the paper to understand what the authors are doing.



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Were variable names cut and pasted from the Stata output?

In general, the table is too cluttered. There is too much going on...

Measure in 1000s of \$s.
I don't need to know the effect down to the penny

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What is the treatment? Use the notes to provide some sense of what is being estimated and how.

Period here instead of colon

Now you can use a colon here

Table 1. Years of schooling and hourly wages: restricted to respondents ages 25-45

	Men		Women	
	wages	ln(wages)	wages	ln(wages)
Schooling	5.64 (5.11)	.054* (.030)	7.83** (3.55)	.094*** (.007)
Observations	12,385		12,012	

Notes: The sample is restricted to CHAT respondents ages 25-45 from Colorado, Nebraska, and Iowa whose wage was greater than or equal to \$3.25 per hour. Each column reports an estimate from a separate OLS regression of wages on years of schooling. Controls include race, ethnicity, marital status, union status, years of experience, tenure at current job, and firm size. Standard errors clustered at the state level are reported in parentheses.

* Statistically significant at the 10% level; ** at the 5% level; *** at the 1% level.

Ideally, you provide enough information in the notes to the table so that the reader can interpret the estimates without having to read the text.

Keep the table uncluttered. Don't report the estimated coefficients of the controls.